

WRITING MODULE:

The Writing Process

“THE CONSEQUENCE [OF WRITING] IS THAT YOU MUST START BY WRITING THE WRONG MEANINGS IN THE WRONG WORDS; BUT KEEP WRITING UNTIL YOU GET TO THE RIGHT MEANINGS IN THE RIGHT WORDS. ONLY IN THE END WILL YOU KNOW WHAT YOU ARE SAYING.” —PETER ELBOW

Writing is a **process** that is done through a series of stages:

I. Prewriting

II. Drafting

III. Editing, and Proofreading

Narrowing down the Topic

- _ Having a narrowed down topic helps with some of the other steps of the writing process:
- • **Research**: o While doing a little preliminary research might be useful to know more about the topic and its stakes, doing too much research on a very broad topic is both time-consuming and counterproductive, as most of the facts and the information that are gathered will not be used in the final version of the paper.
- • **Brainstorming**: o A narrowed down the topic helps focus the brainstorming session around questions and ideas that are manageable in the scope of the paper.
- • **Establishing a thesis**: o A narrowed down topic often elicits or suggests a question. The answer to that question can then become a preliminary thesis.
- o The next steps of the writing process (creating the outline, writing, and revising) can then naturally flow from this thesis statement.

How to narrow down a topic?

Aspect	Select one perspective/aspect and use it for viewing a problem. For example, instead of studying the different factors that cause cancer, study how smoking can cause lung cancer.
Components/Elements	Figure out if the type or category so you analyze them with more precision. For example, a study on the use of tobacco among teenagers can be narrowed down to chewing tobacco instead of all forms of tobacco use or teenagers in general.
Place	In general, analyzing a smaller geographical unit means a narrow topical focus. For example, instead of studying trade relations in Asia, focus on trade relations between China and Singapore guide you in explaining problems in that region.
Time	By adding a time frame it narrows . For example, instead of studying trade relations between China and Singapore, focus on the trade relations between China and Singapore between 2010 and 2018

To narrow down a specific topic, follow these steps:

1 Choose/ provided a general topic area.

An example could be ***employee turnover***.

2. Give specific description of the topic area.

Example: ***turnover in the nursing industry***

3. Mention an aspect of the specific topic:

Example: ***factors that affect turnover among registered nurses in Pakistan***

4. Note down extra specifics about the topic.

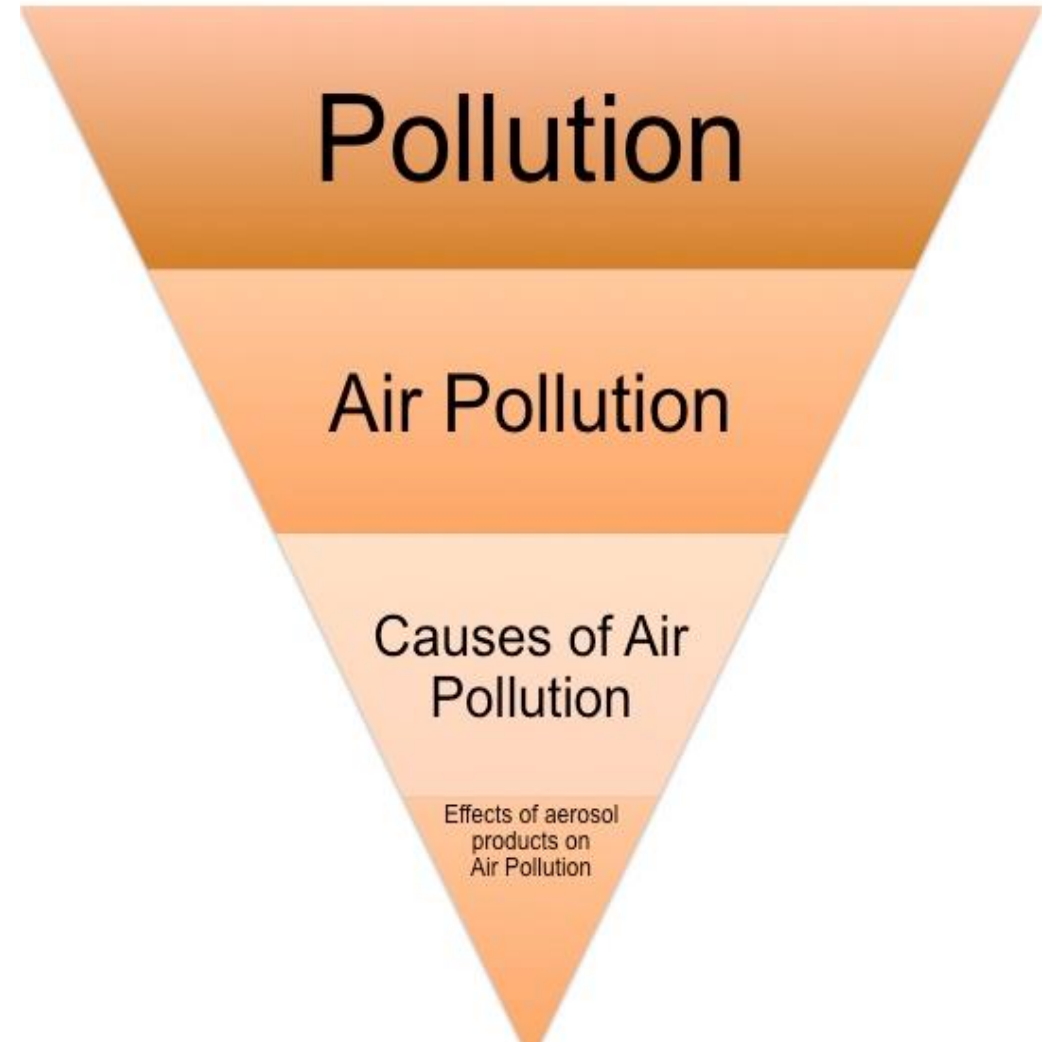
Example: ***Workplace stress and turnover among registered nurses in Pakistan during Covid 19.***

Narrow Down Your Topic

- Your topic should pass the 3-question test:
 - Does it interest me?
 - Do I have something to say about it?
 - Is it specific?

Research Topic Triangle:

The research topic triangle illustrates how a broader topic can be focused by adding keywords to concentrate upon a specific research area.



Example

- What about the seal hunt?
 - Which society?
 - Which more specific group in that society?
 - What kind of effects?
- The effects of the seal hunt on society
 - The effects of the seal hunt on Newfoundland
 - The effects of the seal hunt on the Green's Pond community
 - The economic effects of the seal hunt on the Green's Pond community

• **EDUCATION**



- Education by private institutes in Pakistan



- The education at FAST NU, Lahore



- The quality of education in CS department at FAST NU.

• **Practice Topics**

- 1. Culture
- 2. Festivals
- 3. Environment
- 4. Happiness

Writing a Thesis Statement

Every kind of essay should have a thesis statement, which is usually the last sentence of the introductory or first paragraph.

A thesis statement generally consists of two parts:

your **topic**, and the **main point**: the analysis, explanation(s), or assertion(s) that you are making about the topic.

OR

Thesis statement = Narrowed topic + main point

Euthanasia is suicidal, it should be banned.

Narrowed topic

main point

Three Point Thesis Statement

A **3-point thesis** statement is a coherent statement that integrates the **three** essential components of a standard **thesis** statement, which include a topic, an assertion, and reasons justifying the claim. Basically, the topic should narrowly **define** the subject.

Thesis statement = Narrowed topic + Main point + First supporting reason or idea + Second supporting reason or idea + Third supporting reason or idea

Ex: Teenagers **should get paid the same wages as adults** because teenage workers **do the same amount of work**, **deserve equal labor rights**, and **need the money**.

Three Point Thesis Statement: More Examples

- **Thesis statement:** Over the years television have made the viewing experience challenging for many viewers because shows are not offered regularly, similar programming occurs at the same time, and commercials are rampant.
- **Topic:** Television viewing
- **Stance:** Challenging
- shows are irregular, similar programming, and bombardment of commercials

Use this graphic for three points

- Sample: I want to argue that social network sites are good for kids and society.
- Now I need to think of three points

Social networks...

(this is your broad
idea or issue)

Connect people (key point #1)

Educate people (key point #2)

Entertain people (key point #3)

THESIS STATEMENT

- The thesis statement is the LAST sentence of your introduction paragraph.
- It outlines the body of your paper by stating your overall opinion and outlining your three main points in the order you will be talking about them.
- Ex: There should be stricter bans on smoking (opinion) because it is detrimental to the smoker (1), people around the smoker (2), and the environment (3).



Pre-Writing Strategies

- Pre-writing is an informal process that allows you to explore ideas as they occur to you.
- There are five main strategies for getting started on any writing assignment:
 - 1. Free-writing
 - 2. Brainstorming
 - 3. Listing
 - 4. Clustering
 - 5. Outlining

Free-Writing

- ❑ Free writing is just what it says—writing freely, whatever comes into your mind, without caring about spelling, punctuation, etc.
- ❑ It helps you know where your interests lie.

Example

Here's a sample free-writing that could yield a number of topics for writing:

I don't think this is useful or helpful in any way. This is stupid, stupid, stupid. I'm looking out of my window and it's the end of may and I can see that white cotton stuff flying around in the air, from the trees. One of my aunts was always allergic to that stuff when it started flying around in the spring. Don't know offhand what type of tree that comes from. That aunt is now 94 years old and is in a nursing home for a while after she had a bad episode. She seems to have one now every spring. It's like that old tree cotton triggers something in her body. Allergies. Spring. Trying to get the flowers to grow but one of the neighbors who is also in his 90s keeps feeding the squirrels and they come and dig up everyone's flowerbed to store their peanuts. Plant the flowers and within thirty minutes there's a peanut there. Wonder if anyone has grown peanut bushes yet? Don't know . . . know . . .

Brainstorming

- ❑ What is it? Brainstorming is creating a list of ideas in response to a problem or question.
- ❑ Similar to freewriting, the ideas generated by brainstorming don't need to be related to each other; they only need to be related to the problem at hand.
- ❑ This technique can be done in a group or by yourself.
- How would I use it?
- There are two main ways of brainstorming:
 - 1. Posing and answering questions about a problem or topic: Who? What? Where? When? Why? How?
 - 2. Gathering a list of ideas related to the problem or topic.

- For example, if you are brainstorming about your favorite food, you would make a list of all the sensory information about that food. What does it look, feel, taste, smell, and sound like? From there, you could list how it became your favorite food, the events with which it is associated, how you prepare it, etc.
- For example, if the main topic is “apples”:
- My favorite type-Honey Crisp See-pinkish red skin with some orangey yellow mixed in, it is shiny.
- Feel- smooth skinned Sound (when bitten)-there is a snap when teeth pierce the skin and then a crunch. Etc...

Listing

- ❑ Listing is a process of generating a lot of information within a short time by generating some broad ideas and then building on those associations for more detail.
- ❑ Jot down all the possible terms that emerge from the general topic you are working on.
- ❑ Simply write down as many possibilities as you can.

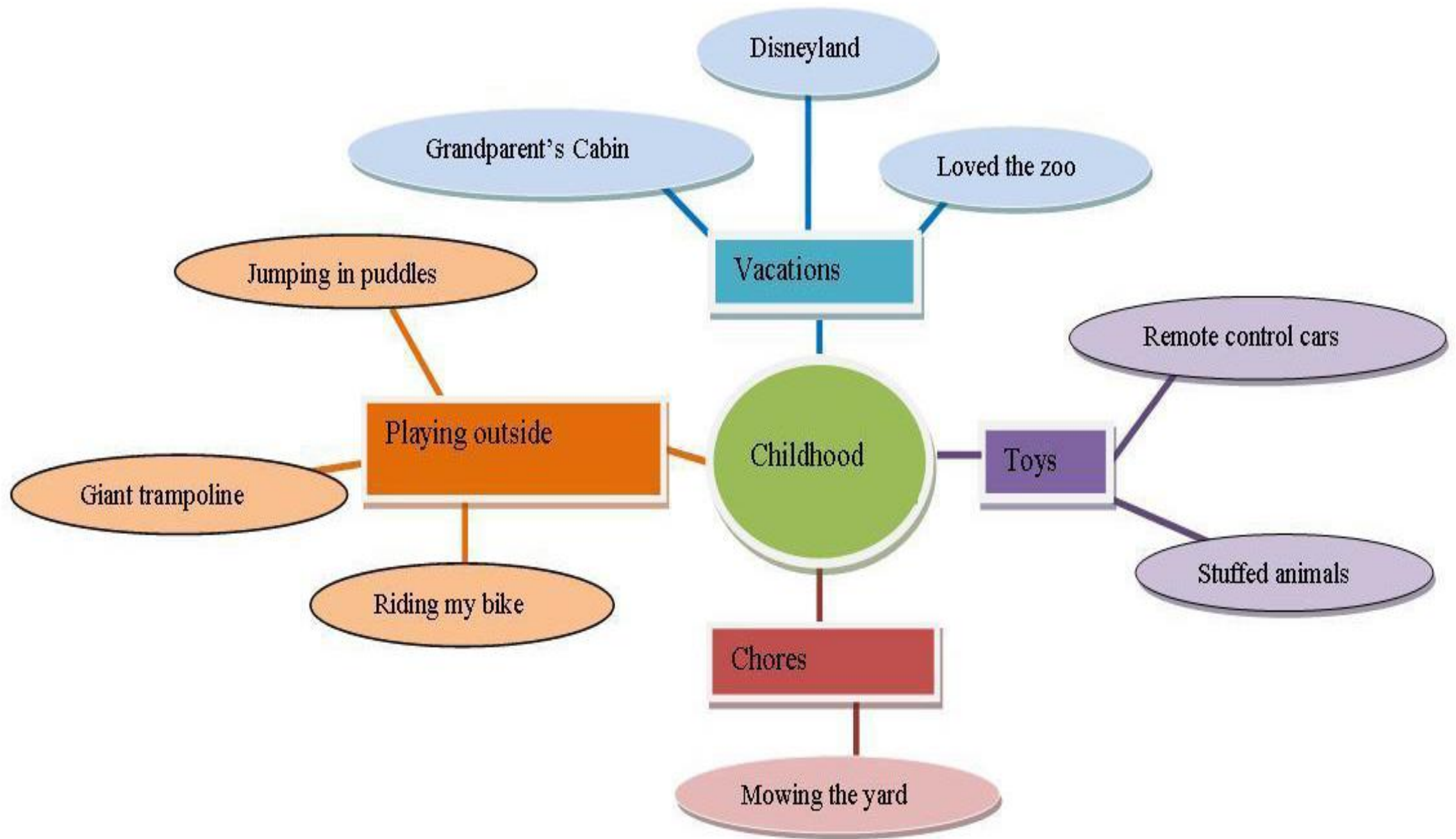
- If you want to take a stand on a subject, you might list the top ten reasons why you're taking that particular stand.

Example: *“Ways to live a greener life”*

1. Use natural cleaning products without propellants
2. Walk or bicycle to places nearby
3. Use recycled products
4. Take public transportation
5. Recycle cans and bottles
6. Use non-life-threatening traps instead of chemical squirrel repellents
7. Reduce carbon footprint
8. Plant trees
9. Use organic food
10. Use products with no toxins

Clustering

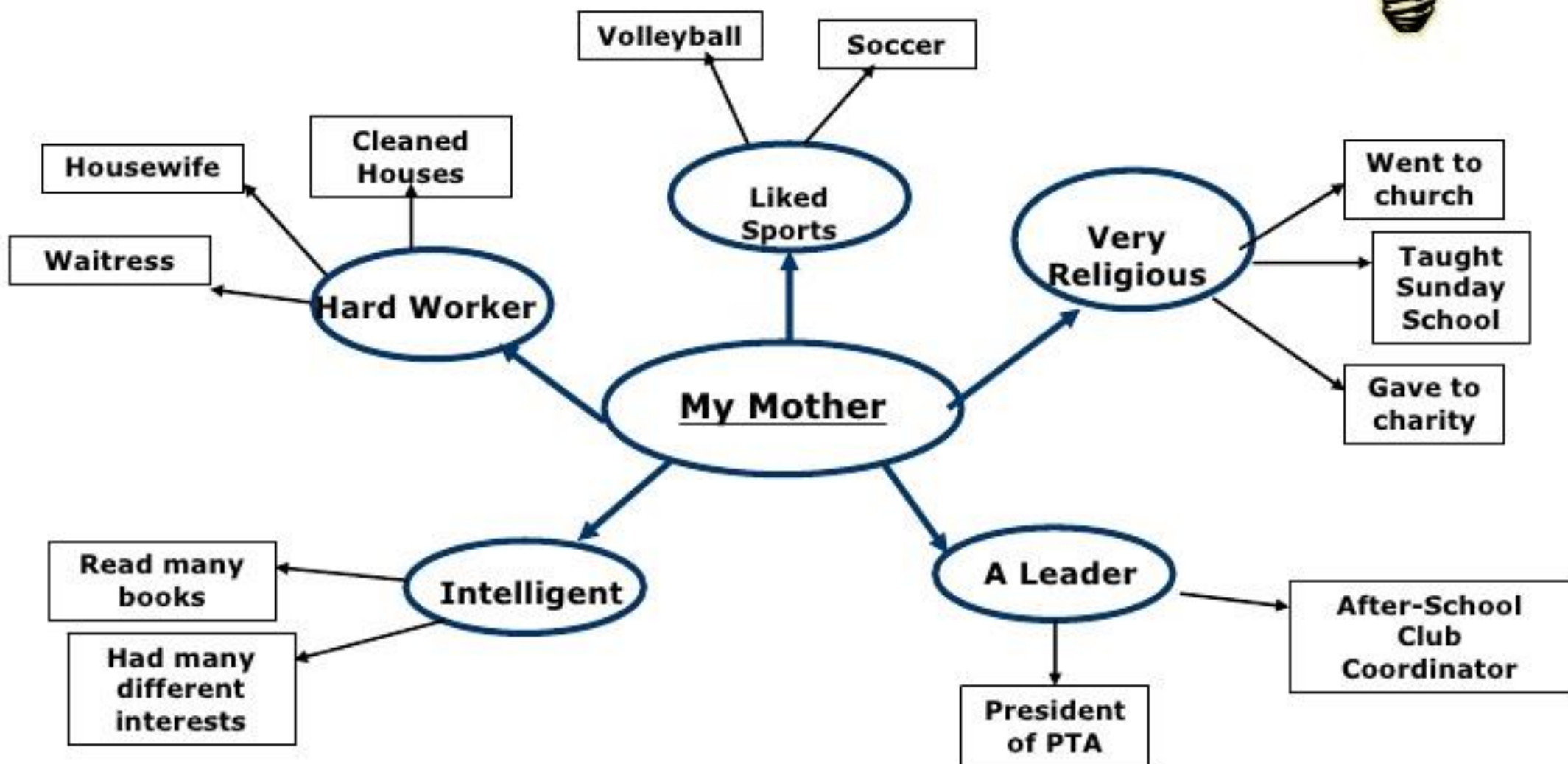
- ❑ What is it? Clustering utilizes a visual map to shape ideas and explore how those ideas relate to each other.
- Helpful tip: When you cluster, your topic goes in a bubble in the middle of the page. From there, your ideas expand to form a spider-web visual.



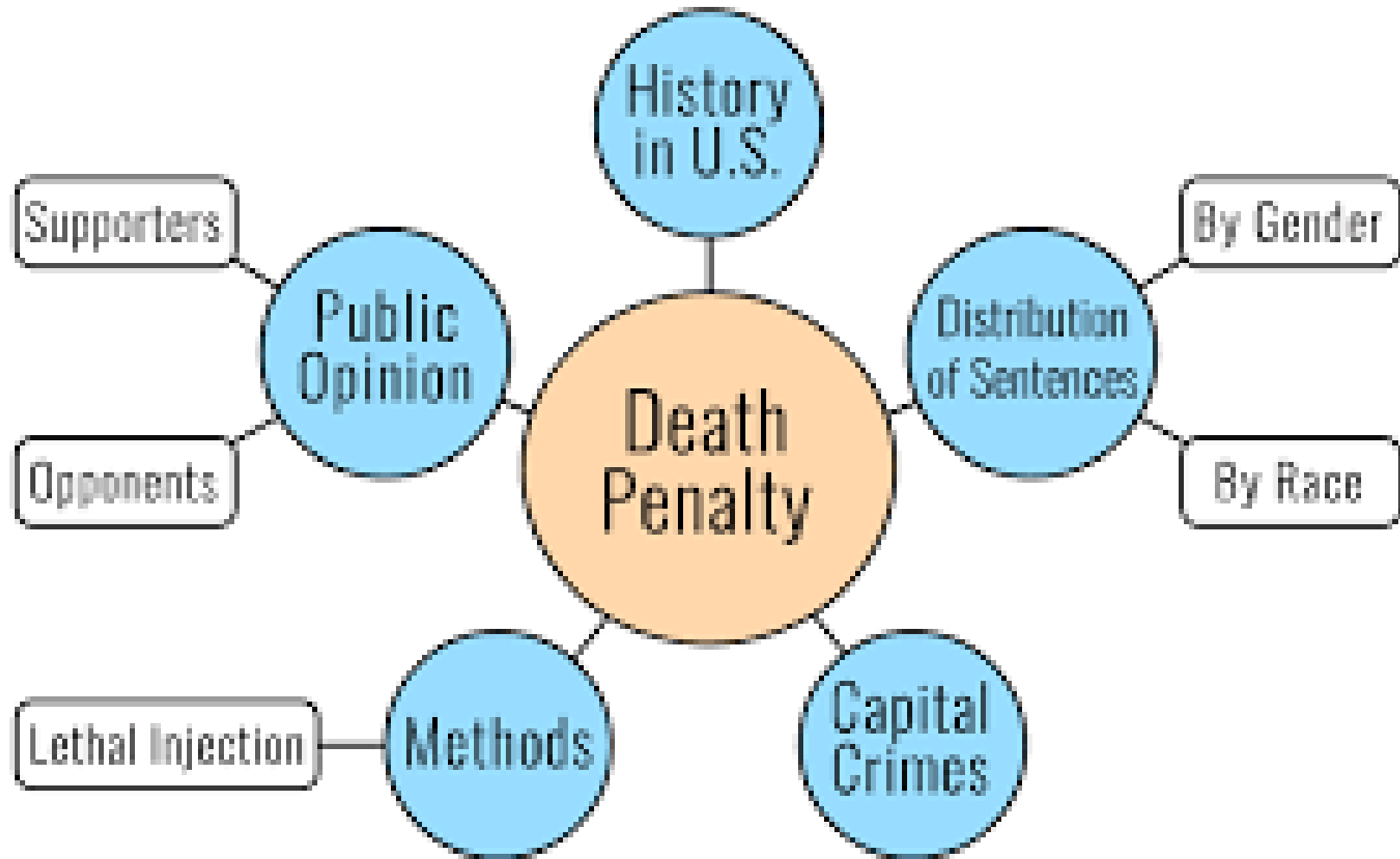
✓ **Clustering**
Listing
Freewriting

Clustering

Example #2



Clustering: Example 3.



Outlining

- ❑ Especially for long papers, outlines can be quite detailed, but even a short outline can be helpful in giving the writer ideas and a sense of organization for an essay.

Examples

After looking carefully at Migrant Mother, John feels that he has identified three important ideas that might be the focus of his essay. He writes down these ideas:

- I. The family is living in severe poverty.
- II. The mother is trying to care for her family.
- III. The mother is determined not to be defeated by her difficulties.

The family is living in severe poverty.

- a. The mother is a migrant--a poor farm worker.
- b. It is 1936, during the "Dust Bowl."
- c. Their clothing is dirty and tattered.
- d. Some of the clothing is too big.
- e. Their skin is dirty: they have not bathed recently.
- f. They appear to be living in a tent.

The mother is trying to care for her family.

- a. The mother is at the center of the photograph--the center of the family.
- b. Two of her children are resting on her shoulders.
- c. The children appear to have recent haircuts.
- d. A baby is asleep in her lap.
- e. The baby may have just been breastfed.

The mother is determined not to be defeated by her difficulties.

- a. The mother is not looking down in defeat.
- b. The mother is looking ahead.
- c. Her hand on her cheek makes her look focused.
- d. She is not even distracted by the photographer.

INTRODUCTION

BODY

I. MAIN POINT

A. Subordinate point (level 1)

1. Subordinate point (level 2)

a. Subordinate point (level 3)

b. Subordinate point (level 3)

i. Subordinate point (level 4)

ii. Subordinate point (level 4)

2. Subordinate point (level 1)

II. MAIN POINT

A. Subordinate point (level 1)

B. Subordinate point (level 1)

1. Subordinate point (level 2)

2. Subordinate point (level 2)

III. MAIN POINT

CONCLUSION

II. Drafting - Putting your ideas and thoughts together in sentences and paragraphs.

- In this part, you will organize all of your notes from your pre-writing. Look at your notes and organize them into separate paragraphs. These paragraphs should be supportive of your introduction and your thesis statement. Everything needs to flow smoothly.
- The conclusion, or "end", of your article should sum up what you have said, without repeating too much. It should give the reader some final thoughts on the topic you are writing about.

III. Revising is rewriting or rearranging sentences to make sense.

- ☐ making decisions about how you want to improve your writing
- ☐ looking at your writing from a different point of view
- ☐ picking places where your writing could be clearer, more interesting, more informative and more convincing.

Smoking-related diseases cause an estimated 440,000 American deaths each year. Even with facts like these, the whole country is divided on this issue. Some people believe that smoking should be banned everywhere while others are not so harsh. I believe, however, that tobacco should be outlawed because smoking endangers everyone's health, pollutes the environment, and drains us of valuable energy.

Hook (Interesting Fact)

Brief Explanation
(Leads into thesis)

Thesis
(What you will be proving)

A Bad Thesis Statement	A Good Thesis Statement
There are some negative and positive aspects to the Banana Herb Tea Supplement.	Because Banana Herb Tea Supplement promotes rapid weight loss that results in the loss of muscle and lean body mass, it poses a potential danger to customers.

Practice 1: Directions: Read the outline and write a thesis statement.

Topic: Young people should pay attention to politics.

- A. Young people are intelligent enough to understand what's going on.
- B. Politics affects everyone's lives, including young people.
- C. Paying attention to politics now will help young people to be informed citizens when they are old enough to vote.

Practice 2: Construct a thesis statement on any one of the narrowed down topics given below:

Darkside of Social Media

OR

Causes of Obesity

Writing the Topic Sentence

A topic sentence is the most important sentence in a paragraph.

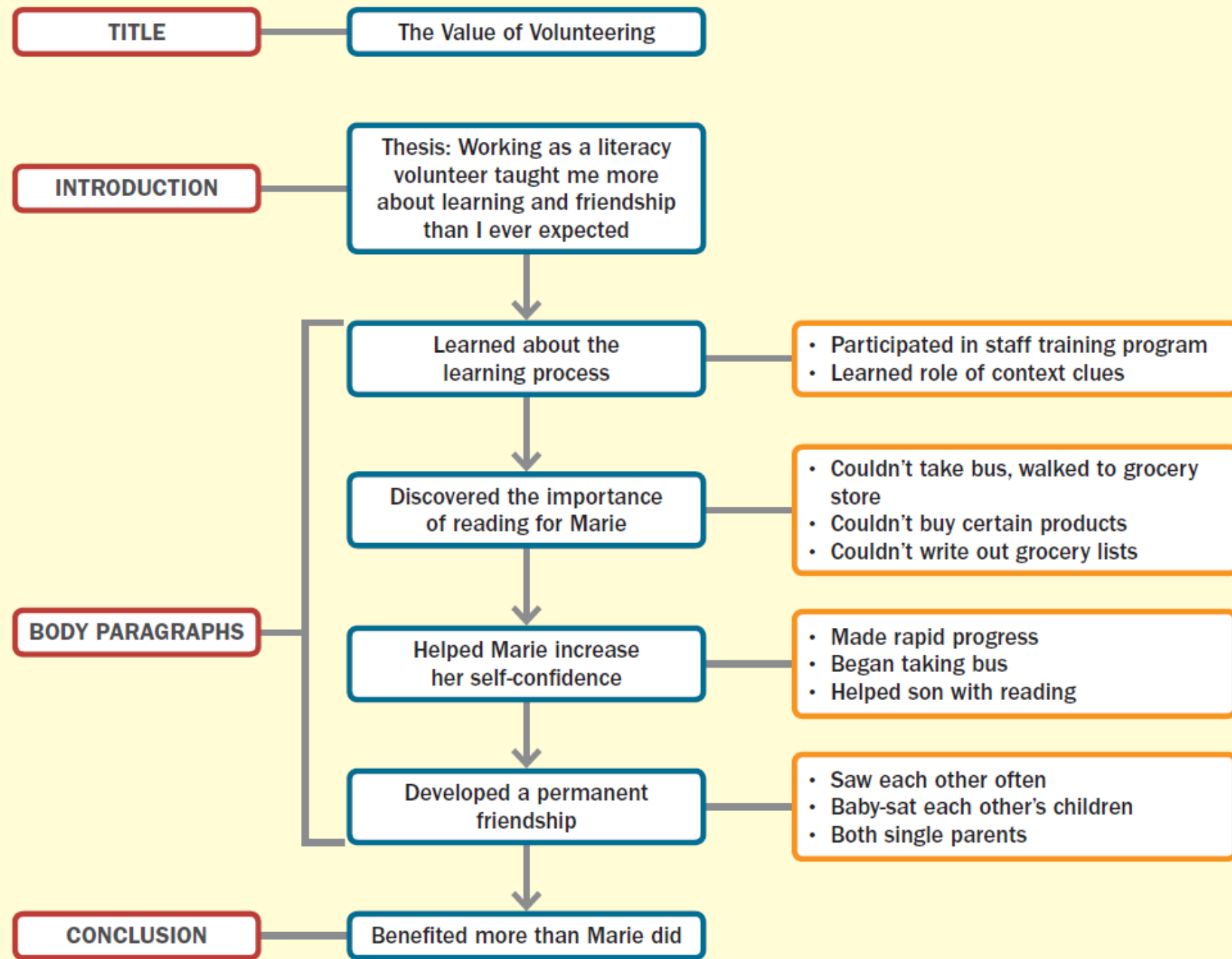
1. A topic sentence is a complete sentence; that is, it contains a subject, a verb, and (usually) a complement. The following are not complete sentences:

- Driving on freeways
- The importance of gold
- How to register for college classes

2. A topic sentence contains both **a topic** and **a controlling idea**. It names the topic and then limits the topic to a specific area to be discussed in the space of a single paragraph.

- Driving on freeways requires skill and alertness.
- Gold, a precious metal, is prized for two important characteristics .
- Registering for college classes can be a frustrating experience for new students.

LOGICAL RELATIONSHIP	TRANSITIONAL EXPRESSION	(P:205 – PDF file)
Similarity	also, in the same way, just as ... so too, likewise, similarly	
Exception/Contrast	but, however, in spite of, on the one hand ... on the other hand, yet, nevertheless, nonetheless, notwithstanding, in contrast, on the contrary, still,	
Sequence/Order	first, second, third, ... next, then, finally	
Time/Narrative/ Chronology	after, afterward, at last, before, currently, during, earlier, immediately, later, meanwhile, now, recently, simultaneously, subsequently, then	
Example	for example, for instance, namely, specifically, to illustrate	
Emphasis	even, indeed, in fact, of course, truly	
Place/Position	above, adjacent, below, beyond, here, in front, in back, nearby, there	
Cause and Effect	accordingly, consequently, hence, so, therefore, thus	
Additional Support or Evidence	additionally, again, also, and, as well, besides, equally important, further, furthermore, in addition, moreover, then	
Conclusion/Summary	finally, in a word, in brief, briefly, in conclusion, in the end, in the final analysis, on the whole, thus, to conclude, to summarize, in sum, to sum up, in summary	



Practice

Prompt 1: What type or types of technology would you like to see in the college classroom? How would you like to see this technology used?

Prompt 2: If you could create a mobile application for an iPhone or iPad, what would it be?

Prompt 3: What is your favorite technological device? (Example: computer, phone, iPod etc.)